

Alibaba Group (BABA): 4QFY26 Earnings First Take

Alibaba delivered mostly in-line 4QFY26 (March quarter) results at +3% group top line growth (~1% below GSe/V.A.) and -84% yoy in group EBITA (-2% vs. GSe, but -58% below V.A. Consensus). eCommerce CMR came broadly in-line at +1% yoy (GSe: +1%, V.A.: +4%, or +8% yoy like-for-like ex. changes to merchant incentives booking), overall cloud/external cloud growth/EBITA margins were at +38% yoy/+40% yoy/9.1% EBITA margin, that came in broadly in-line with GSe/V.A., accelerated from last quarter, with AI accounted for 30% of external cloud revenues (triple-digit growth for the 11th consecutive quarter). All others losses widen to Rmb-21.2bn (wider than GSe/V.A. of Rmb-19.1bn/-15.3bn) due to increased AI investments (notably investment in user acquisition of Qwen app during CNY) and AI model investments/Alibaba Token Hub consumer+enterprise offerings. The company also laid out details of Alibaba's AI infrastructure/full-stack AI footprint, highlighting progresses across Qwen Model Family (Qwen3.6-Plus launch with enhanced benchmark results), T-Head chips (proprietary AI chips scaling in adoption, with 100K+ Zhenwu PPU deployed) and Qwen's consumer AI application (with 158+mn MAU in April 2026 and recent integration with Taobao shopping).

We expect key focus on the results call to be on: 1) Any commentaries on strategic priorities for the new fiscal year, between protecting Taobao-Tmall market share, maximizing core cash flow generation to fund AI capex (as capex exceeds annual EBITA) and the investment scale for AI models, To-B and To-C AI initiatives; **2) How Alibaba Cloud evolves its pricing and MaaS frameworks** to transition customers toward the multi-year contract structures seen in US hyperscalers (with end-of-quarter backlog becoming a key quarterly metric), and how the new Alibaba Token Hub (Wukong enterprise platform) specifically facilitate this long-term enterprise lock-in, note that customer base for Model Studio grew by 8X yoy as of March 2026; **3) Current ARR scale compared with local peers**, how much of MaaS is driven by Qwen vs. third-party models, and the strategic outlook for scaling this; **4) Implications for cloud margin outlook** on the back of recent cloud price hikes, and how to quantify benefits on token efficiencies from T-head; **5) Profit outlook for Taobao-Tmall for FY27** with a flattish eCommerce industry profit pool, and the latest GMV growth trend.

By segments:

- **Key numbers: 1)** Taobao-Tmall CMR revenue growth came in in-line at +1% yoy, where we note the comparable number excl. contra revenue impact from new merchant incentive program reached +8% yoy, with China E-commerce Group

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EBITA decrease of -40% yoy (broadly in-line with GSe/V.A. at -42%/-38%). **2)** cloud revenue growth +38% yoy, below expectation with GSe/Visible Alpha Consensus Data at +40%. Cloud margin came in in-line at 9.1% (vs. GSe/V.A. of 9.0%). **3)** Group non-GAAP EPADS declined -95% yoy, below GSe and Consensus Data by 10%/42% at -85%/-53%. **4)** Capital expenditure came in below expected at Rmb26.9bn (up 9% yoy while -21% below GSe), from Rmb29bn in Dec quarter.

- **Alibaba International Digital Commerce Group:** revenue came in at Rmb35.4bn, **+6%** yoy (2% above GSe at 4%), amongst which International retail/International wholesale revenues grew by **+5%/+9%** yoy. Adj. EBITA at Rmb-0.1bn and **+96%** yoy, on significant improvement in logistics optimization and operating efficiency, with unit economics of AliExpress' Choice sequentially improved.
- **All Others:** total revenue came in at Rmb65.5bn, -21% yoy and adj. EBITA loss came in at Rmb-21.2bn (vs. Rmb-7.7bn loss a year ago and Rmb-9.8bn loss in Dec qrt). The profit decrease is primarily attributable to the increased technology investments, while partly offset by the improved results from Cainiao, Hujing Digital Media and Entertainment Group, etc.
- The aggregate amount of the annual dividend will be approximately US\$2.5bn.

We are **Buy-rated** on BABA/9988.HK, with 12-month target prices at US\$186/HK\$180 based on SOTP. **Key risks:** Lower-than-expected GMV growth due to macro/competition; Slower-than-expected monetization in China retail; Weaker-than-expected execution in key strategic investments; Cloud revenue growth deceleration.

The author would like to thank Iris Xiao for her contribution to this report.

Exhibit 1: 4QFY26 results at a glance

Rmb mn	Actual	GSe	Cons	Act vs Est	Act vs cons	% yoy
4QFY26 total revenues	243,380	245,724	246,193	-1%	-1%	3%
Customer management revenue (CMR)	73,024	72,136	74,048	1%	-1%	1%
Cloud Intelligence Group revenue	41,626	42,042	42,118	-1%	-1%	38%
4QFY26 adjusted EBITA	5,102	5,192	12,191	-2%	-58%	-84%
4QFY26 non-GAAP EPS (Rmb)	0.62	1.89	5.88	-67%	-89%	-95%

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, Visible Alpha Consensus Data

Exhibit 2: 4QFY26 results overview (group)

By segment (Rmb mn)	1QFY25	2QFY25	3QFY25	4QFY25	1QFY26	2QFY26	3QFY26	4QFY26	4QFY26E	Diff.	QoQ	YoY
Group revenue	243,236	236,503	280,154	236,448	247,652	247,795	284,843	243,380	245,724	-1%	-15%	3%
yoy %	4%	5%	8%	7%	2%	5%	2%	3%	4%			
Group EBITA	45,035	40,561	54,853	32,616	38,844	9,073	23,397	5,102	5,192	-2%	-78%	-84%
EBITA margin %	19%	17%	20%	14%	16%	4%	8%	2%	2%			
yoy %	-1%	-5%	4%	36%	-14%	-78%	-57%	-84%	-84%			
Adj. net profit attributable to shareholders	40,265	36,363	51,332	29,980	35,291	10,450	17,112	1,506	4,159	-64%	-91%	-95%
Adj. net margin %	17%	15%	18%	13%	14%	4%	6%	1%	2%			
yoy %	-10%	-9%	7%	18%	-12%	-71%	-67%	-95%	-86%			
Non-gaap EPS (Rmb)	16.44	15.06	21.39	12.52	14.75	4.36	7.09	0.62	1.89	-67%	-91%	-95%
yoy %	-5%	-4%	13%	23%	-10%	-71%	-67%	-95%	-85%			
By Business group												
China e-commerce business group												
GMV (GSe)	2,103	1,843	2,439	1,688	2,208	1,946	2,390	1,772	1,772	0%	-26%	5%
yoy %	8%	2%	4%	5%	5%	6%						
China e-commerce business group revenue	127,670	114,773	150,589	115,348	140,072	132,578	159,347	122,220	124,762	-2%	-23%	6%
yoy %*	1%	4%	7%	9%	10%	16%	6%	6%	9%			
Customer management revenue (CMR)	81,088	71,667	101,834	72,180	89,252	78,927	102,664	73,024	72,136	1%	-29%	1%
yoy %	2%	4%	11%	14%	10%	10%	1%	1%	1%			
China e-commerce business group EBITA	48,753	44,327	60,401	39,742	38,389	10,497	34,613	24,010	23,954	0%	-31%	-40%
EBITA margin %	38.2%	38.6%	40.1%	34.5%	27.4%	7.9%	21.7%	19.6%	19.2%			
yoy %	3%	-1%	6%	7%	-21%	-76%	-43%	-40%	-42%			
Cloud intelligence Group												
Revenue	26,549	29,610	31,742	30,127	33,398	39,824	43,284	41,626	42,042	-1%	-4%	38%
yoy %**	6%	7%	13%	18%	26%	34%	36%	38%	40%			
EBITA	2,337	2,661	3,138	2,420	2,954	3,604	3,911	3,796	3,784	0%	-3%	57%
EBITA margin %	8.8%	9.0%	9.9%	8.0%	8.8%	9.0%	9.0%	9.1%	9.0%			
Alibaba International Digital Commerce Group												
Revenue	29,293	31,672	37,756	33,579	34,741	34,799	39,201	35,429	35,040	1%	-10%	6%
yoy %	32%	29%	32%	22%	19%	10%	4%	6%	4%			
EBITA	(3,706)	(2,905)	(4,952)	(3,574)	(59)	162	(2,016)	(138)	(53)	-163%	93%	96%
EBITA margin %	-12.7%	-9.2%	-13.1%	-10.6%	-0.2%	0.5%	-5.1%	-0.4%	-0.2%			
All others												
Revenue	81,354	84,483	89,234	83,276	58,599	62,969	67,340	65,459	64,778	1%	-3%	-21%
yoy %	5%	6%	6%	0%	-28%	-25%	-25%	-21%	-23%			
EBITA	(1,077)	(1,833)	(3,176)	(3,413)	(1,415)	(3,370)	(9,792)	(21,160)	(19,110)	-11%	-116%	-520%
EBITA margin %	-1.3%	-2.2%	-3.6%	-4.1%	-2.4%	-5.4%	-14.5%	-32.3%	-29.5%			
Share of loss in equity investees	1,505	978	3,129	354	1,013	2,241	216	(685)	296	-331%	-417%	-294%
Ant Financial (33%. 1qr lag pick up)	3,917	2,478	4,490	1,763	1,547	2,733	393	375	1,393			
Others	(588)	(746)	39	(981)	455	671	696	(198)	(822)			

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

BABA	12m Price Target: \$186.00	Price: \$134.78	Upside: 38.0%
9988.HK	12m Price Target: HK\$180.00	Price: HK\$133.30	Upside: 35.0%

Buy CL		GS Forecast			
		3/25	3/26E	3/27E	3/28E
Market cap: \$323.5bn	Revenue (Rmb mn)	996,347.0	1,026,014.2	1,130,069.8	1,240,785.7
Enterprise value: \$305.8bn	EBITDA (Rmb mn)	202,325.0	112,258.4	157,988.3	242,211.5
3m ADTV: \$1.4bn	EPS (Rmb)	65.81	28.49	40.69	57.37
China	P/E (X)	10.1	32.1	22.5	16.0
China Ecommerce & Logistics	P/B (X)	1.6	2.0	1.9	1.7
M&A Rank: 3	Dividend yield (%)	2.0	1.6	1.7	1.9
Leases incl. in net debt & EV?: No	N debt/EBITDA (ex lease,X)	(1.2)	(1.7)	(0.6)	(0.3)
	CROCI (%)	14.3	7.0	10.0	13.3
	FCF yield (%)	4.8	(1.3)	(2.2)	1.2
		9/25	12/25	3/26E	--
	EPS (Rmb)	4.36	7.09	1.89	–

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 12 May 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

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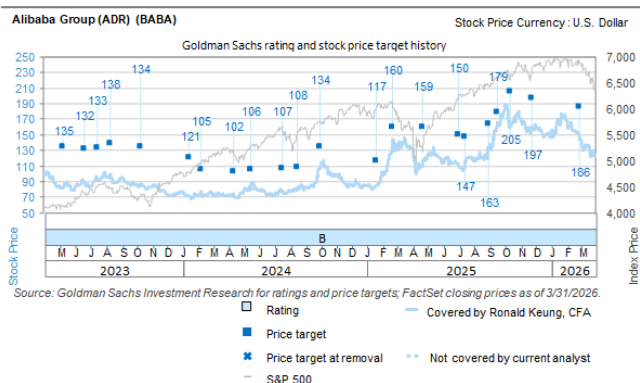
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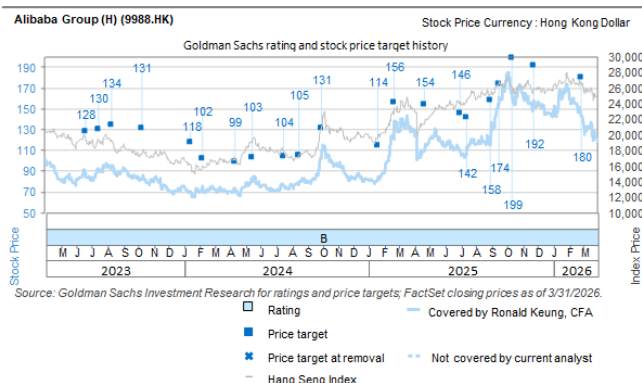
	Rating Distribution			Investment Banking Relationships		
	Buy	Hold	Sell	Buy	Hold	Sell
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Target price history table(s)

Alibaba Group (ADR) (BABA)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
27-Feb-26	186.00	144.11
25-Nov-25	197.00	157.01
12-Oct-25	205.00	159.01
16-Sep-25	179.00	162.21
31-Aug-25	163.00	135.00
15-Jul-25	147.00	116.97
02-Jul-25	150.00	110.71
21-Apr-25	159.00	110.15
20-Feb-25	160.00	135.97
20-Jan-25	117.00	85.12
29-Sep-24	134.00	107.33
15-Aug-24	108.00	79.54
16-Jul-24	107.00	78.38
15-May-24	106.00	80.99
11-Apr-24	102.00	74.85
07-Feb-24	105.00	73.64
15-Jan-24	121.00	71.84
09-Oct-23	134.00	84.85
10-Aug-23	138.00	99.21
16-Jul-23	133.00	94.56
20-Jun-23	132.00	87.93

Alibaba Group (H) (9988.HK)

Date of report	Target price (HK\$)	Closing price (HK\$)
27-Feb-26	180.00	142.90
25-Nov-25	192.00	157.80
12-Oct-25	199.00	165.40
16-Sep-25	174.00	153.50
31-Aug-25	158.00	115.70
15-Jul-25	142.00	113.50
02-Jul-25	146.00	109.40
21-Apr-25	154.00	108.70
20-Feb-25	156.00	120.90
20-Jan-25	114.00	84.55
29-Sep-24	131.00	102.50
15-Aug-24	105.00	76.40
16-Jul-24	104.00	75.50
15-May-24	103.00	82.65
11-Apr-24	99.00	74.20
07-Feb-24	102.00	74.90
15-Jan-24	118.00	70.00
09-Oct-23	131.00	82.10
10-Aug-23	134.00	94.30
16-Jul-23	130.00	92.95
20-Jun-23	128.00	88.35

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